Common Errors in Students' Writing

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Functional English (SS1012)

1. Subject-verb agreement

- Subject-verb agreement is the rule in English grammar that requires a sentence's verb to match its subject in number (singular or plural). A singular subject takes a singular verb, while a plural subject takes a plural verb.

Singular Subject:

If the subject is singular, the verb should also be singular.

Example: The dog barks.

Plural Subject:

If the subject is plural, the verb should be plural.

Example: The dogs bark.

Exceptions for "I" and "You":

The pronouns "I" and "you" are exceptions to the "s" rule. Even though "I" is a singular subject, it takes the plural form of the verb, and "you" always takes the plural verb form, regardless of whether it refers to one person or many.

Example: I walk to the park. You walk to the park.

Compound Subjects Joined by "And":

Two or more subjects joined by the word "and" typically create a plural subject and require a plural verb.

Example: The boy and the girl are playing.

Compound Subjects Joined by "Or" or "Nor":

When two singular subjects are joined by "or" or "nor," they are treated as a singular subject and require a singular verb.

Example: Either Tina or Rohit is telling the truth.

Phrases Between Subject and Verb:

Phrases or clauses can appear between the subject and the verb. The verb must still agree with the subject, not with words in the intervening phrase.

Example: The woman, along with her children, is going to the store.

2. Run-on sentences

- Run-on sentences occur when two or more independent clauses are joined incorrectly. Without the proper punctuation or conjunctions, these sentences become confusing and overwhelming. Clarity begins with knowing where one thought ends and another begins.

You can correct a run-on sentence by using one of these methods:

Use a fullstop:

Separate the independent clauses into two complete sentences.

- Incorrect: The day was bright, we decided to go to the beach.
- Correct: The day was bright. We decided to go to the beach.

Use a semicolon:

Connect two independent clauses that are closely related in meaning.

- Incorrect: My phone died, I needed to find a charger.
- Correct: My phone died; I needed to find a charger.

- **Use a comma and a coordinating conjunction:**

Add a comma and a joining word (like for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) between the clauses.

  - Incorrect: The dog barked, the cat ran away.
  - Correct: The dog barked, so the cat ran away.

- **Make one clause dependent:**

Turn one of the independent clauses into a dependent clause by adding a subordinating word (like because, since, although, when).

  - Incorrect: The rain started, we had to cancel the picnic.
  - Correct: Because the rain started, we had to cancel the picnic.

3. Using informal language or contractions

- Academic writing demands a formal tone. Using casual language or contractions (like *don't* or *won't*) can make your work seem unpolished or too conversational. Aim for a professional, objective, and respectful tone of the subject matter.

Contractions

Informal: The results don't show a clear pattern.

Formal: The results do not show a clear pattern.

Casual Words/Phrases

Informal: Kids these days spend too much time online.

Formal: Children today spend a considerable amount of time online.

Personal Opinions

Informal: I think this study is really interesting.

Formal: This study presents significant and noteworthy findings.

Conversational Style

Informal: Lots of people were against the idea.

Formal: A large number of individuals opposed the idea.

Vague Language

Informal: The experiment kind of failed at the start.

Formal: The experiment initially encountered difficulties.

Slang/Colloquial Expressions

Informal: The company was doing great until things went south.

Formal: The company performed well until it experienced a downturn.

4. Redundant phrasing and wordiness

Wordy: In my personal opinion, I think that online learning is beneficial.

Concise: In my opinion, online learning is beneficial.

Wordy: The reason why students fail is because they do not prepare.

Concise: Students fail because they do not prepare.

Wordy: At this point in time, we cannot draw a conclusion.

Concise: At present, we cannot draw a conclusion.

5. Unnecessary or missing comma

- Commas may be small, but they carry a lot of weight. Misplacing or omitting them can alter the meaning of a sentence or make it hard to follow. Knowing where to pause—and where not to—is crucial for clarity.

✖ Before conducting the survey the researchers obtained approval.

✔ Before conducting the survey, the researchers obtained approval.

Placement of commas can change the entire meaning of a sentence:

Let us eat grandpa.
Let us eat, grandpa.

A woman: without her man, is nothing.
A woman, without her, man is nothing.

6. Unnecessary or missing capitalization

- Capitalization errors often stem from over-correction or misunderstanding what counts as a proper noun. Academic writing requires consistency, and excessive or omitted capital letters can be distracting.

✖ The University conducted a study on student government in nigeria.

✔ The university conducted a study on student government in Nigeria.

7. Unnecessary or missing hyphen

- Hyphens help clarify meaning, especially in compound words. Without them, phrases can become ambiguous or grammatically incorrect. Understanding when to hyphenate improves both readability and precision.

  ✖ The study used a well known method.

  ✔ The study used a well-known method.

Hyphenated Compound Words	
Sister-in-law	Self-control
Self-esteem	T-shirt
Cross-country	Over-the-counter
Mother-in-law	Off-road
Co-worker	High-definition
Semi-automatic	Pre-employment
State-of-the-art	Under-the-table
Up-to-date	Half-hearted
X-ray	Long-term


lunch-time → lunchtime
room-mate → roommate
bed-time → bedtime
mis-prints → misprints

8. Spelling and typos

- Even the strongest arguments can be undermined by a simple typo or misspelled word. While spellcheck helps, it doesn't catch everything. Always proofread carefully.

  ✖ The researchers recieved unexpected results.

  ✔ The researchers received unexpected results.

Some Commonly Misspelled Words

❌ Misspelled	✅ Correct
definately	definitely
recieve	receive
adress	address
accomodate	accommodate
occured	occurred
seperate	separate
goverment	government
recomend	recommend
enviroment	environment
tommorow	tomorrow
calender	calendar
Febuary	February
beleive	believe
wich	which
succesful	successful
arguement	argument

9. Wrong word choice or form

Choosing the wrong form can confuse your reader or alter your intended message. Careful word choice enhances clarity and professionalism.

Affect vs. Effect

❌ Wrong: The new law will have a positive affect on small businesses.

✅ Correct: The new law will have a positive effect on small businesses.

❌ Wrong: The medicine effected her mood.

✅ Correct: The medicine affected her mood.

2. Then vs. Than

❌ Wrong: She is taller <u>then</u> her brother.

✅ Correct: She is taller than her brother.

❌ Wrong: First we’ll go shopping, and than we’ll eat lunch.

✅ Correct: First we’ll go shopping, and then we’ll eat lunch.

3. Its vs. It’s

❌ Wrong: The company increased it’s profits last year.

✅ Correct: The company increased its profits last year.

❌ Wrong: The cat hurt its paw, and its not walking properly.

✅ Correct: The cat hurt its paw, and it’s not walking properly

4. Your vs. You’re

❌ Wrong: Don’t forget you’re books at home.

✅ Correct: Don’t forget your books at home.

❌ Wrong: Your going to love this movie.

✅ Correct: You’re going to love this movie.

10. Confusing homophones

- Words that sound the same but have different meanings—like *their*, *there*, and *they're*—can easily confuse students. These errors stand out in academic writing and should be carefully avoided.

HOMOPHONE	HOMOPHONE EXAMPLES
Their / There / They're	Their (possessive pronoun): *The researchers presented their findings at the conference. (Belongs to them)* There (adverb/place): *The lab is located over there, near the main entrance. (Refers to a location or place).* They're (contraction of they are): *They're conducting interviews all week.*
Its / It's	Its (possessive pronoun): *The company updated its cybersecurity policy. (Belongs to them)* It's (contraction of it is or it has): *It's important to cite all your sources.*

11. Faulty parallelism

- **Parallel structure (also called parallelism)** in writing means using the **same grammatical form or pattern** when expressing related ideas in a sentence or list. It makes writing clearer, smoother, and more professional.

❌ Faulty: She likes reading, to jog, and swimming.

✅ Correct: She likes reading, jogging, and swimming.

❌ Faulty: The new policy will affect how employees work, their pay, and if they get promotions.

✅ Correct: The new policy will affect how employees work, how they are paid, and how they are promoted.

❌ Faulty: The teacher said we should complete the assignment on time, that we must study for the test, and being respectful in class.

✅ Correct: The teacher said we should complete the assignment on time, study for the test, and be respectful in class.

❌ Faulty: She is more dedicated than her brother and works harder than anyone.

✅ Correct: She is more dedicated than her brother is and works harder than anyone does.

12. Vague pronoun reference

Pronouns should clearly refer to a specific noun. When it's unclear what "it," "they," or "this" is referring to, the reader may get lost. Clear pronoun use is essential for reader comprehension.

❌ When the researchers interviewed the participants, they were confused.

✅ The participants were confused when the researchers interviewed them.